

REMEMBERING THE LIFE AND SCHOLARSHIP OF ALFRED “TUNA” SNIDER

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The late Alfred Snider, or “Tuna” as he was affectionately known by colleagues and friends, was the Edwin W. Lawrence Professor of Speech and Debate and Director of the Lawrence Debate Union at the University of Vermont. He had an outstanding career as a debate coach, scholar, teacher, mentor, and activist. Dr. Snider was a central figure in the communication and debate community for the last forty-three years. Grounded in the disciplines of public address, rhetoric, and argument, his imagination and implementation of innovative ideas has forever changed forensics and communication studies. Dr. Snider’s work was motivated by his belief that language, when adopted as civil dialogue, could play a substantial role in changing a world plagued by violence towards a global environment where social, cultural, and political, struggles were peacefully resolved through productive dialogic exchange. Described by the *New York Times* as an “evangelist who sought to heal the world through debate,” (Fox, 2015), Dr. Snider was one of the leading debate practitioners of his era and arguably the greatest global ambassador of debate as a tool for critical thinking, persuasion, and argumentation. His mission to spread debate to those who most needed it—e.g. areas of war, conflict, and autocracy—took him all over the world. In this quest, Dr. Snider started The World Debate Institute, which started as a small debate instruction program based out of the University

of Vermont. Throughout his later years, he grew the Institute to match its name and his vision for a global debate community by creating and supporting debate programs in Palestine, Iraq, Turkey, Estonia, Qatar, and countless others. In addition to his tenure at the University of Vermont, Dr. Snider also served as a faculty member at Beihang University in Beijing in China, visiting faculty at the University of Belgrade, the Kyushu University of Japan, and the University of Primorska, Slovenia.

Tuna started debating in the seventh grade, competed through high school, and was a nationally ranked intercollegiate debater for Brown University. After earning a Ph.D. from the University of Kansas, Dr. Snider went on to author five books and over fifty journal articles. The majority of his publications attended to the practice of debate and its role in global social change. His commitment to free information exchange drove his early adoption of the internet. Understood as a powerful tool of education, Tuna created various websites devoted to debate education. The most comprehensive, Debate Central (hosted by the University of Vermont), contains a seminal collection of teachings and resources for coaches and students. The website continues as an invaluable assemblage of debate knowledge.

In addition to his commitment to debate education, Dr. Snider helped to spread the rhetorics of peace and justice embodied in reggae music. For fifteen years, he hosted the “Reggae Lunch”—a weekly radio program on the University of Vermont’s college radio station, WRUV 90.1 FM. He was the co-founder of the Vermont Reggae Festival, and at the University of Vermont, he taught the Rhetoric of Reggae music, one of the University’s largest and most popular courses. Dr. Snider was also an avid fan of the long-running British

television series, *Dr. Who*, playing an active role in the fan community. Further, his civic engagement extended through his production of the weekly public affairs television program, *Flashpoint*, in which he collaborated with students to debate topics addressing pressing political issues. He filmed hundreds of episodes at the studios of Vermont Community Access Media (VCAM) in Burlington, Vermont. Tuna passed away just months before the 500th episode was scheduled to be filmed.

This brief synopsis of the contributions of Alfred Snider gives only a fragment of his life’s work, and is most certainly incomplete. He was a man of many gifts and talents, and he shared those talents in a multitude of ways, with too many people to count. This collection of essays is conceived as a tribute to honor some of Dr. Snider’s many great contributions. Given his over forty-year career and tireless effort to do good and important work wherever and whenever it was most needed, any collection honoring those talents will inevitably be partial. Instead, we conceive of this collection of essays as a beginning, and an invitation to others, to both reflect on and continue Tuna’s important, and vitally necessary, work. When Tuna passed away, literally thousands of people wrote messages on his social media pages, detailing the ways in which he influenced them to do better and more meaningful work in their own lives. These essays are but a small sliver of those sentiments. The authors featured in this special issue have had the privilege of working with Tuna in various capacities and at distinct stages in his career. They are educators from diverse areas of the world. Some of the essays are written by former mentees and others more contemporary collaborators, each touched by Dr. Snider’s socially conscious mission to offer all global citizens the tools to replace weapons with words.

In addition to contributions by educators and

scholars reflecting on Tuna's life and scholarship, we are pleased to include in this special issue an essay Tuna was in the process of completing. With the support of the Senior Editors of *Contemporary Argumentation and Debate*, we open this collection with an unpublished essay authored solely by Dr. Snider— "From Resolution to Motions: Moving in a Different Direction." We have deliberately made no revisions to this essay, but we encourage readers to appreciate it was still in the process of completion prior to this publication. Dr. Snider's introductory essay provide readers precious insight into Tuna's thinking just prior to his passing. Here he offers American coaches and debaters an understanding of the World Universities Debate format (also known as British Parliamentary debate)—a format with little academic writing, a great deal of global popularity, and increased interest by United States debate teams. Tuna traces different formats of U.S.-based intercollegiate debate from the early 1990's to the present. He argues that the increase of United States debate teams shifting to World's style formats requires a change in motion/topic construction and overall orientation to the literature.

Following Tuna's essay, the issue then turns to what is perhaps his most significant scholarly contribution to debate theory and the discipline: gaming theory. Between 1984 and 2003 Dr. Snider published several articles which argue that most American policy debate adjudicators rely on gaming or game theory as their default paradigm, although few debate judges acknowledge it. Matthew G. Gerber and Jeff Nagel's contribution to this issue supports Tuna's theory and argues that the gaming paradigm "has publically proliferated and become a topic of active debate among critics. . ." (p. 46). In "Final Frontier: The Perpetual Explanatory Power of Alfred Snider's Gaming theories

for Contemporary Intercollegiate Policy Debate," Gerber and Nagel extend Snider's gaming theory scholarship based on evidence they collected at the 2016 National Debate Tournament. They conclude that gaming theory is useful to not only make sense of the distinction between "policy" and "performative" debate styles but also accommodates them both. They support these findings with five important arguments: gaming is a framework within which multiple paradigms can compete; gaming allows for non-traditional styles of debate to extend language that accommodates performance; gaming models can work to the advantage of all types of debaters in multiple formats; the gaming model makes debate accessible to the general public; and gaming allows for all aspects of the game to be debatable, with limited rules and procedures. Using these arguments, Gerber and Nagel affirm that Snider's theory of gaming continues to be central to the current American policy debate community.

In addition to gaming theory, another important scholarly contribution Tuna made was in research on the value and practice of debate across the curriculum, or, in other words, debate in educational environments beyond the more formal competitive debate community. In 2002, Dr. Alfred Snider and Dr. Maxell Schnurer, in their book *Many Sides: Debate Across the Curriculum*, argued that structured classroom debates (SCDs) facilitate numerous pedagogical benefits and can be easily adapted for use in a wide array of undergraduate courses. Merrell, Calderwood, & Graham's section of this collection, "Debate Across the Disciplines: Structured Classroom Debates in Interdisciplinary Curricula," draws on these 2002 findings to determine why SCD's are so frequently neglected. Coupled with traditional lecture, these authors agree with Snider and

Schnurer's findings and suggest that SCD's are a very effective tool "at deepening students' comprehension of course content and enthusiasm for the subject matter" (p. 70). Merrell, Calderwood, & Graham highlight some potential challenges to classroom debate, including formats, topics, education criteria, audience participation, and student apprehension. However, they conclude that structured classroom debates are especially successful in interdisciplinary university courses and Merrell, Calderwood, & Graham encourage university instructors to overcome their fears and embrace the educational benefits of SCD in their courses.

Gina Iberri-Shea's contribution continues to defend the benefits of debate as a mode of education. In her essay, "Many More Sides: Debate Across the Curriculum and Around the Globe," Iberri-Shea extends Dr. Snider's advocacy for the dissemination of debate in education by highlighting the many ways in which English language learners benefit from a curriculum that includes debate. Drawing from her own experience teaching language learners in Italy and the Czech Republic, Iberri-Shea concludes that debate not only overcomes the limitations of traditional education systems, but also has important inherent intersections with language learning content, critical thought, and communication. Debate requires students to practice note taking, reading, writing, careful listening, oral presentation, argument construction, and engaging in intercultural communicative competence. While the background of participants and contexts of debate change, what unifies the activity, Iberri-Shea contends, are two core requirements: "The program uses authentic texts, authentic interaction, and meaningful content" and "combines language, content, and learning objectives, and is adapted to the needs of a particular

group of students" (p. 86-87). In an effort to continue Tuna's legacy, Iberri-Shea argues that incorporating debate in language education across the curriculum emboldens students with the power to effectively participate in global citizenship.

Building on the theme of the significance of debate for participating in global practices of citizenship, Luis M. Andrade's and Brenda Montes' essay, "Conexiones in Venezuela: Dr. Snider's Cross-Cultural Empowerment Pedagogy," advocates for the importance of Tuna's pedagogy of cross-cultural empowerment. Reflecting on their experience teaching debate alongside Tuna in Venezuela, Andrade and Montes understand cross-cultural empowerment pedagogy "as an approach to teaching that adapts to students' different learning styles, needs, socio-economic backgrounds and cultures..." (p. 95). They describe that it was quickly evident that the students who engaged in the debate workshop had a "sincere yearning to promote public dialogue at the national level" (p. 94). Andrade and Montes make connections between Paulo Freire's pedagogies of the oppressed and Tuna's conception of debate as a dialogic system of advocacy. They contend that Dr. Snider was "an exemplary educator that embodied the Freirean spirit of empowerment, liberation, and revolutionary dialogue" (p. 103). Snider's collaboration, or *conexión*, style enables debate workshops to promote relational connections between teachers and participants. After the conclusion of Snider's debate workshop these authors learned that their debate students used the skills they learned to take part in *The Movimiento Estudiantil*—a national student movement advocating for social change. It was then these authors concluded that Dr. Snider was teaching more than a competitive game; he was teaching the foundation of revolutionary education.

Jason L. Jarvis' essay also speaks to Dr. Snider's influence on the international debate community and introduces readers to common colloquiums, or "Tunaisms," that Tuna used to explain the amazing potential of global debate in catchy and virally spreadable terms. Jarvis' article, "Spaceship Earth: The Global Legacy of Dr. Alfred 'Tuna' Snider," is an attempt to recognize and record Tuna's activist agenda to teach debate as a means to encourage global dialogue. Having worked with Tuna on several occasions (South Korea, Bangladesh, Slovenia, Thailand, Canada, Ireland and Iraq), Jarvis aims to demonstrate the great influence the World Debate Institute had on argument communities globally. Specifically, Jarvis takes up two debate programs that were heavily influenced by the teachings of Dr. Snider, the South Korean and Iraqi debate communities. This essay provides unique insights into how Tuna facilitated teachings to support the Asian Debate Institute and the Iraq Debate Academy. Together these examples, Jarvis concludes, demonstrate that Tuna's debate education model necessitates learning from other cultures and building bridges with non-Eurocentric communities.

Dr. Snider's debate teachings are also taken up in Piyanart Faktornngpan's contribution, "An Investigation of Successful Argumentative Strategies in Debating." Faktornngpan's scholarship fills a significant void in research that rarely focuses on a detailed examination of the argumentative patterns debaters use to win debates. Drawing on Snider's claim that the A-R-E Format (Assertion, Reason, and Evidence) can be used to teach students to make strong arguments, as well as, Snider's emphasis on short points of information, this qualitative essay collects data from forty-five speeches that contain points of information to effectively support Snider's theory. Now that the Ministry of Education

in Thailand is funding debate as an extra-curricular course for all public schools nationwide, Faktornngpan's research is instrumental to teachers and coaches training throughout the country.

In "Digitisation, Education and Debating: Taking Forward the Ideas and Inspiration of Alfred Snider into the Digital Age," Mike Douse draws from the significant influence Dr. Snider had on secondary schools in the developing world. Specifically, Douse recognizes the massive and productive changes that digitisation can have on debate education at all levels of education. While the benefits of public speaking are well documented, the attributes of debate—"creativity, self-esteem, information analysis, teamwork, research skills and effective listening all come into play in debating and certainly relate to academic performance" (p. 137)—Douse suggests that debate adds importance to the ways in which oral education is advanced. Contemporary technology, Douse argues, provides universal and immediate access to increase participation in oral information exchange. Douse draws this conclusion by taking up the exemplar of the *The School*—a universal school in a rural disadvantaged area, made up of an inclusive mixed age classroom, catering to learners who are engaged in global speaking, free connectivity, prepared teachers who digitally support learning, access to devices and software, and a system geared toward lifelong higher education. For these students, more than enabling intentional debate, digitisation "heralds a fresh educational era" in which the central pedagogical curriculum mirrors academic debate (p. 143). Douse concludes his essay by returning to Tuna's mantra that the time is right to disseminate the tools of debate to create hope and possibility for everyone, not just a privileged few. For Douse, digitisation has made Tuna's

desire a possibility and a goal all curriculums (from primary to higher education) should seek to achieve.

Tuna's early adoption of the internet and his use of it to spread free, educational, debate material to the world is in many ways rooted in his intellectual affinity for the teaching of Ivan Illich. Helen Morgan Parmett's (Tuna's current successor and the current Director of the Lawrence Debate Union) addition, "Debating Convivially: Alfred Tuna Snider's Illichian Approach to Debate & the University," takes up Tuna's Illichian thinking. Illich, she cites, was "a philosopher and social critic of Western culture and its industrial institutions" (p. 147). In this essay, Morgan Parmett focuses particular attention on Illich's concept of conviviality, an "ethical value and method for evaluating society's relationship to its 'tools'" to determine if they prioritize individual freedom (p. 147). She argues that conviviality played a central role in Tuna's framing of debate as a tool that empowers debaters to think for themselves and endows them with the capability to respond to demanding global concerns by participating in democracy without passively supporting institutions that all too often ignore the best interests of individual freedom. After explaining Illich's theory of conviviality and Dr. Snider's adoption of this theory, Morgan Parmett applies Tuna's pedagogy to the critical juncture of contemporary debate. She accentuates two underlining "sites of transformation that debate is undergoing"—1) the globalization of debate and its embedded resistance to debate's history of white supremacy and colonialism; and 2) the corporatization and monetization of debate. Attending to these trajectories in a way that liberates debate and debaters from the institutions in which they are embedded requires, she concludes, participants strive to make debate more convivial.

Also drawing on Tuna's investment in Ivan Illich,

Stephen M. Llano's essay, "Tuna's Legacy as A Challenge to Communication Scholarship: An Embodiment of Work," invites readers to make sense of Tuna's non-traditional notion of scholarship. Dr. Snider's style, Llano argues, challenges the conventional modes of scholarship (a mode this collection falls prey to) by limiting his involvement with peer-reviewed journals and conferences and instead participating in engaged scholarship—a practice that includes critical, oral and active teachings, events, workshops, and broadcasts. Tuna's engaged scholarship, Llano explains, is "an alternative to the traditional mode of university experience for students, preferring community-based education to one where knowledge is distributed from experts to those who are students" (p. 162). This type of engagement includes civic-scholastic pursuits, where Tuna made a difference in communities by teaching global debate workshops in which he emboldened students to become debaters and thus anti-intuitionist thinkers. Llano explains Tuna's scholarship is a testament to Dr. Snider's agreement with the teachings of Ivan Illich. Tuna's desire to create large worldwide debate communities was a modern up-take of Illich, in which publications were not "cogs in the larger modern research university complex" but instead "a dynamic, unfinished process" where multiple meanings are created, circulated, and calls for response (p. 165). The debate tournament was not something simply administered or directed by Dr. Snider, it was a challenge to the traditional mode of scholarship and was his radical site of active publication, embodied scholarship, and invention.

Tuna also had a great passion for the British science fiction television program *Doctor Who*. In his essay, "Doctor Who? Doctor Tuna!", Sam Nelson draws three quintessential comparisons between Doctor Who and

Dr. Snider—their control of time, interactions with companions, and the boundless desire to do good. Due to Tuna’s great fascination, Nelson understands these comparisons as not only accurate, but also a great tribute to Dr. Snider. Nelson begins by situating the ways in which Dr. Who—a Time Lord with a command of time-travel technology—was similar to Dr. Snider, whose command of digital technology enabled him to participate in several events simultaneously. Next, Nelson carefully considers the ways in which both doctors interacted with companions. He applauds the variety of partners that accompanied each doctor on various missions. Drawing examples from different episodes of *Dr. Who*, Nelson reflects on the ways in which both Dr. Who and Dr. Snider attracted and interact with their companions. Finally, this essay ends by complimenting Tuna’s desire to do good through a final comparison with Dr. Who. While the televised Doctor fought literal Monsters, Nelson describes Tuna as also battling “metaphorical monsters in his attempt to save things he held near and dear to his heart” (p. 175)—his students, his friends, and his belief that debate could benefit the world.

This tribute concludes with a previously unpublished interview of Alfred Snider conducted by his student Delainey LaHood-Burns. In 2015, LaHood-Burns was working for one of Burlington, Vermont’s community-based radio stations. As part of her affiliation with the station, and specifically the program “Big Heavy World,” LaHood-Burns brings this special issue and celebration of life to a close by offering readers the influential words of the late Dr. Alfred “Tuna” Snider. This interview highlights his enthusiasm for all his work. In the interview, Snider discusses a range of issues we believe will be of keen interest to readers: his passion for the internet as a vehicle

of information dissemination and networking; the importance of teaching debate as an alternative to war; the value of educating youth and judging their success not by how well they do, but instead by “how far they come” (p. 184). Snider, in his own words, describes the magic of watching the transformation in individuals when they find their voice; the ways in which he was able to find his own voice; his understanding of the role and power of television; as well as his belief in the successes, and possibilities, of the University of Vermont Debate Team.

The impact of Dr. Snider’s teachings continues to develop through the practices, scholarship, and activism of his students, colleagues, friends, and family. While each of the essays in this special issue draws from the teachings of Dr. Snider, again, we recognize that his accomplishments far exceed the limits of this collection. We are optimistic that this is a beginning of reflections that will continue to draw from the various aspects of Tuna’s work. It is our hope that future uptakes of Dr. Snider’s teachings will take place not only in traditional scholarship, but also in the kind of embodied scholarship that Tuna practiced. There is little doubt that Tuna would be surprised to see how and what ways world politics has changed in the short time since his passing. Yet, we can confidently argue that, for Dr. Snider, the answer to divisiveness is more debate. Or, as he liked to say, “the solution to this problem is more debate!” The fields of communication, argumentation, forensics, and the global debate community will forever be impacted by the legacy of achievements left by the late Alfred “Tuna” Snider. We thank him for the many gifts he has left us, as we take to heart his enjoinder to “get to work!”

References

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